

The Weight of Mercy

A Psychological Novel Inspired by Dostoevsky

Chapter One: The Fever of Thought

It was not guilt that woke him at dawn, but the unbearable heat in the room. The air was heavy, soaked with July humidity, and even the faded curtains seemed to droop under its weight. Elias Morin turned over in his cot, trying to escape the sunbeam that had sliced through a gap in the fabric and now burned the side of his face. He had not slept well — again. Sleep had become a series of anxious fragments, broken up by sudden bursts of thought, each more disturbing than the last.

The room, a small rented flat on the edge of the Old District, was barely large enough for a bed, a desk, and a crooked shelf cluttered with books. The wallpaper peeled like dry bark from the walls, and the wooden floor bore old, dark stains he never dared investigate. But none of it mattered to Elias. Not the squalor, not the heat — only the thought that had rooted itself so deeply in his mind that even sleep could not choke it out.

One death for a hundred lives. One life for redemption. That was the thought.

He sat up abruptly, rubbing his forehead, which felt clammy and fevered. His dark eyes scanned the desk where a notebook lay open. Lines of ink trailed across the page, more erratic toward the end — notes written under the haze of some inner storm. The words didn't form arguments; they formed justifications.

Was it madness to plan a murder? Or madness to see clearly what others were too afraid to see?

Elias was twenty-six, a former philosophy student at the city university before his scholarship was revoked for “uncooperative behavior” — which was a polite way of saying he had argued with a professor in front of an auditorium, disassembled his thesis line by line, and accused him of cowardice. The administration had called him unstable. But he saw it differently. He believed he simply possessed the courage to follow a truth to its dark end.

And the truth, as he now saw it, was that the world was built on rot.

The wealthy fed on the desperation of the poor. Men who preached morality owned slaves of the modern kind: those who bled in silence to keep machines running, kitchens open, towers clean. Justice was a word printed in courtrooms, but Elias had once watched a homeless boy imprisoned for stealing bread. His friend Clara had died of an infection that would have been cured easily if her insurance had not expired.

Why, he asked himself, should one not remove a rotting tooth from the mouth of society?

And that tooth had a name: Gregor Andelov. A pawnbroker. A swindler. A man who made his wealth lending money at cruel interest to the desperate — and worse, who had long been rumored to exploit his female clients behind closed doors. The man was untouchable in court. A patron of the arts. A silent donor to the police guild.

Elias had studied him for weeks. He knew the times Gregor left his shop. Knew his building had no security cameras. Knew that on Friday nights, Gregor often came home drunk after visiting the theater.

It would be quick, Elias thought now, wiping sweat from his brow. It would be simple. No one would even suspect. And after... after the world might tilt ever so slightly toward balance.

But even as the rational parts of him clung to this logic, a shadow moved in the corners of his thoughts — a whisper, something older than reason. A hesitation.

He heard the front door of the boarding house creak open and the clomp of boots on the stairs. Probably his neighbor, Julian, returning from another night shift at the steel plant. Elias stayed silent, listening. Silence was his comfort these days. He feared conversation. Feared it might betray what he was thinking.

He moved to the window and opened it slightly, hoping for air. Below, the street was already alive with the groans of the city — a vendor's call, the hiss of a tram line, a siren in the distance.

And in the midst of all this life, Elias stood above with his thought: to kill.

He had given himself one week. Seven days. If by then he had not found another answer — another way to disrupt the machine — he would act.

He closed the window, shut the curtain, and walked to his desk. He stared at the notebook again. The last line read:

"Some truths must be baptized in blood."

He capped his pen. Then slowly, methodically, he began to prepare.

Chapter Two: The Stranger in the Rain

That afternoon brought a rainstorm, sudden and uninvited, as if the sky itself had burst from pressure too long ignored. Elias hadn't left the building all day, but by five o'clock, hunger pushed him from his room. The bakery across the alley sold old bread for half-price in the evenings. It was a habit formed from poverty, but now it served another purpose: routine. Disguise.

He donned his coat, the same charcoal-gray wool he'd worn since university, and stepped into the misting street. Rain pattered lightly against his shoulders. The city was blurred, dreamlike, with fog rising from the cobblestones and the neon signs glowing like embers through the haze. He liked the city this way — half-hidden. As if the truth of it only emerged when people hurried by with their collars up and their heads down.

Elias passed a man huddled under an awning, clutching a soiled blanket and muttering into the wind. A dog barked somewhere in the alley behind the grocer's. The smell of wet garbage and engine oil hovered low to the ground.

As he turned the corner, Elias nearly collided with someone — a man in a long overcoat, holding a black umbrella.

"Pardon me," Elias muttered, stepping aside.

The man, middle-aged and clean-shaven with steel-rimmed glasses, simply stared at him for a moment — not angrily, not suspiciously. Just curiously. Then he nodded once and continued walking.

The moment passed. But it stuck in Elias' mind.

The bakery was lit from within by a single yellow bulb and the smell of old yeast. Behind the counter stood Marcy, the baker's daughter, a thin girl with freckled cheeks and worn fingers. She knew Elias, though they had never truly spoken.

"You're late," she said.

"I always am."

She didn't smile, but she slid two loaves into a paper bag and placed them on the counter. "Still short?"

"I'll pay the rest next time."

"You always say that too."

He nodded in thanks, tucked the bag under his arm, and turned to leave. But before he could step out, she said:

"You should sleep more."

Elias paused, looked back.

"You look haunted."

He opened his mouth but had no answer. Only a dry "thank you" came out. She watched him go.

Outside, the rain had softened to a drizzle, but the clouds remained low and heavy. Elias took the long way back, wandering through a narrow row of abandoned shops. The rain dripped from the awnings. He didn't know why he chose this route. Perhaps he wanted time to think. Or perhaps he wanted someone to stop him.

Near the edge of the Old District, he paused before a building marked Andelov & Co. – Appraisals, Loans, Investments. The sign was faded, the glass dim.

Gregor's shop.

Elias stared at it. He felt no surge of emotion. Only a cold calm. The kind that came just before fever broke.

He crossed the street and approached the iron gate. It was locked, as always, but through the glass door he could see the faint light still on inside.

He stood there for a long moment. Watching. Breathing.

Then a voice behind him said, "Planning a robbery, friend?"

Elias turned sharply. It was the same man from earlier — the umbrella, the glasses, the overcoat. How he had circled back here, Elias couldn't guess.

"No," Elias said, too quickly.

The man smiled. "Then perhaps something more noble. Assassination, maybe?"

He was mocking him. But gently, like a man who knew exactly the line he was pressing on.

"You don't know me," Elias said stiffly.

"No," the man replied, "but I know that look. I've worn it."

He tipped his umbrella slightly and stepped closer.

"You believe there is something in that building that needs to be ended. Not stolen. Not burned. Just... removed. Am I wrong?"

Elias didn't speak. Couldn't. His throat had gone dry.

The man chuckled, as if the answer were already known. Then he extended a card.

"I'm Inspector Kael. I walk these streets when it rains. It reminds me of all the things the sun hides."

Elias took the card, glanced down at the black print. A police seal. A real one.

"Be careful," Kael said. "Sometimes the people who deserve to die... don't. And the ones who kill them? They never get to choose the punishment."

He walked off into the mist.

Elias stood there long after the rain had stopped.

Chapter Three: Clara's Room

The stairs creaked beneath Elias's footsteps as he returned to the boarding house. Every noise seemed louder after the rain — the ticking of the hallway clock, the rustling of someone's newspaper, the groan of old pipes. His mind was not in the room, nor even in the present. It had slipped somewhere in time, to a different part of the city, a different season.

Clara's apartment had always smelled faintly of lavender and ink.

She'd lived in a flat smaller than his, though somehow it had always felt more alive. Books piled on the windowsill, little glass jars of dried flowers, tea cups never quite washed, a piano with one broken key. Clara was what Elias used to call a necessary contradiction — fragile in body but unbending in will. She'd been a violinist and a street performer, a rebel and a romantic, all packed into a soul that had burned too hot for the world she lived in.

She'd also been sick. Not for long. It had started with a cough in winter. By spring, the infection had spread. When the hospital denied her care because her identity papers had expired, she turned to Gregor Andelov.

Andelov gave her a loan — at a rate that bordered on criminal. Elias hadn't known the details at first. Clara hadn't told him. But when she died, the pieces had assembled themselves like glass in the sunlight. There were bruises, unpaid bills, letters from Andelov demanding more than money.

Elias sat now at his desk, the bread untouched. He reached for the notebook again. Its pages had begun to take on a ritual quality — not just plans, but confessions. The kind you whisper to no one but yourself.

He flipped to a new page and wrote:

"There is no such thing as a clean motive. Even justice carries blood on its breath."

The card from Inspector Kael lay beside the notebook. Elias picked it up, turned it in his fingers. Why had the man approached him twice? What did he know?

Or was it a test?

He considered burning the card but tucked it into his coat pocket instead.

He leaned back in his chair and stared at the ceiling, following the cracks like a maze. He saw Clara's eyes. He saw Gregor's crooked grin. He saw the slow, methodical death of things that mattered.

The next day would be Friday. Gregor would go to the theater.

Elias's hand trembled as he reached for the drawer beside his bed. Inside it, beneath a worn copy of The Republic and a photo of Clara, lay a hammer wrapped in cloth.

Chapter Four: The Broken Lock

Friday came with an overcast sky and a strange stillness in the air. It was the kind of weather that seemed to press against the skin like an unseen hand, holding the city under some unspoken pressure. Elias dressed slowly, methodically. His actions were rehearsed — not rushed, but not hesitant either.

He did not eat. Hunger had left him days ago.

The hammer, now wrapped inside his coat, added a subtle weight to his frame. His fingers twitched with every step.

At precisely 6:40 p.m., he stood near the corner across from Gregor's shop. As expected, the lights inside were dim. Gregor's clerk, a weasel of a man named Eren, had already gone home. Elias watched the upper window. A shadow moved — Gregor's figure, pacing, changing clothes perhaps. Preparing for the theater.

At 7:12 p.m., the shop door opened. Gregor emerged in a long coat, cane in hand, walking with his usual limp and looking down his nose as though the entire street was beneath him.

Elias turned away before their eyes could meet. He counted: one... two... three...

He crossed the street. Reached the gate.

Gregor, ever cautious, always double-locked the shop when he left — but he rarely checked the side door. The alley was narrow, garbage-filled, and stank of rusted pipes and cat piss. But Elias had seen it: three weeks ago, the locksmith had come to fix the front. The side entrance had been left untouched.

Elias stepped into the alley and knelt by the door. He took a strip of metal from his coat — once part of a wire hanger, now shaped into a crude pick. His fingers were shaking. He breathed.

In. Out.

Click.

The lock gave with a soft protest.

He paused, listening. Only the distant hum of the city — a streetcar, a dog barking, laughter from the tavern on the corner. Then silence.

He entered the shop.

It smelled of leather, ink, and something rotting beneath. The floor creaked. The curtains were drawn. In the half-light, shapes emerged: glass cabinets filled with jewelry, cameras, watches, violins, locket — the dreams of poor people turned to collateral.

Elias moved to the backroom. The safe was there. He knew the layout. He didn't need the money. He wasn't here to steal.

He was here to end something.

He heard a creak behind him.

Elias froze.

Had Gregor returned?

No.

The creak had come from above — the second floor. Elias had forgotten: Gregor had a niece. Young. Maybe ten or eleven. He hadn't seen her in weeks and assumed she was away with family. But now...

His pulse quickened. Sweat pooled at the base of his neck. He could not kill a man with a child nearby.

He turned toward the back exit, moving quickly and silently.

As he reached the threshold, the front door opened.

Light flooded in.

Gregor.

The old man paused, confused.

Elias was still in the shadows. For one second, Gregor didn't see him.

But that second passed.

"Who's there?" Gregor barked, voice sharp.

Elias raised the hammer. Instinct. Reaction. Panic.

And then time slowed.

Gregor saw him.

His eyes narrowed — recognition? Confusion? Rage?

He reached for something in his coat.

Elias stepped forward.

Chapter Five: The Sound of the Blow

The hammer connected with a sickening thud.

It wasn't strength that delivered the blow — it was fear. An animal fear that surged through Elias like fire, bypassing thought and morality and turning his arm into an instrument. Gregor collapsed with a grunt, eyes wide, his body folding like wet paper to the floor.

Silence.

Elias stood frozen, the hammer still raised, dripping. His breath rasped through his throat like broken glass. The room suddenly felt too small. Too real. The air too thick to breathe.

Gregor groaned.

Not dead.

Elias panicked. He struck again.

And again.

Until the sound stopped.

Until there was nothing left but his heartbeat — loud, deafening — and the echo of something ancient inside him shattering.

He dropped the hammer.

His hands trembled violently as he stepped back, slipping slightly on the blood-slick floor. Gregor's eyes were still open. Lifeless. Fixed in a permanent expression of horror and disbelief. Elias couldn't look away.

Then — a sound.

Footsteps above.

A girl's voice.

"Uncle?"

Elias's spine went cold. His eyes darted to the stairs. The girl. The niece. She was home. She had heard.

No. No. No.

He snatched the hammer, wiped it quickly on his coat, and darted to the back exit. Every part of him screamed to flee, but he forced himself to pause at the alley door. He shut it gently. Too gently. Then he ran.

Chapter Six: The Descent

The rain returned before midnight.

Elias stood beneath an underpass near the old bridge, his coat soaked, his hands still faintly stained. The hammer was gone — thrown into the river without ceremony. He had burned his gloves in a trash barrel near the canal. He'd wiped his shoes on the wet earth. He had done everything according to the plan.

But there had never been a plan for what came after.

His heart had stopped racing, but his mind hadn't. It twisted and gnawed, turning against itself. His thoughts felt like teeth.

He began walking. The streets were quieter now. Drunks and night-watchers passed without noticing him. A police cart trundled by, but did not stop. He didn't know if Gregor's body had been discovered. Didn't care. The blood still pulsed behind his eyes like a drumbeat.

At some point, he found himself at the old university gates. The building loomed like a corpse of ideas — ivy-choked, hollow, rotting. He stared at the old archway. His past. His arrogance. His obsession with morality as an intellectual toy.

He thought of Clara again.

Would she have understood?

Would she have forgiven him?

Lightning flashed. The thunder took longer to follow.

He walked on.

Back at the boarding house, he undressed in the dark. His clothes — bloodied, ruined — he stuffed into a bag and hid beneath the floorboard behind the desk. His heart thudded in his chest as he cleaned his hands again and again in the sink, scrubbing long after the stains were gone.

But the smell wouldn't leave. Nor the sight. Nor the feel.

He collapsed onto the bed, still damp, still shaking.

Sleep came, eventually — not as rest, but as a punishment.

In his dream, Gregor's eyes opened again.

And the girl's voice whispered from the stairwell:

"You killed him."

Chapter Seven: The Visitor

Three days passed.

Gregor's murder flooded the papers. The *Courier du Nord* called it "a heinous slaying of a respected lender." The authorities, Elias read, were "investigating all possible leads." The girl — his niece, Annika — had discovered the body. The article said she was in a state of shock, being cared for by extended family.

No mention of a suspect.

No mention of him.

Still, Elias felt watched. The streets pressed closer. The walls of his flat whispered in the dark. He had stopped eating entirely. Even sleep was dangerous. His dreams were crawling with eyes.

And then came the knock.

Not the landlady. Not a neighbor. A slow, deliberate knock on the door at precisely eight in the morning.

Elias froze.

Another knock.

He opened it.

Inspector Kael stood there, calm as ever, umbrella in hand though there was no rain.

"You look unwell," he said.

Elias didn't answer.

"May I come in?"

Every instinct screamed no, but Elias stepped aside.

Kael moved like a man examining a theater stage before a performance. He looked at the bookshelf. The bed. The desk. He nodded at the notebook.

"You still write?" he asked.

Elias said, "Occasionally."

“Good. Words keep madness at bay. Though sometimes they feed it, too.”

Kael turned suddenly.

“Did you know Gregor Andelov?”

Elias kept his face still. “Only by name. Everyone knew him.”

Kael studied him.

“He was murdered,” Kael said plainly.

“I read.”

Kael took a step closer. “Do you believe in justice, Mr. Morin?”

Elias swallowed. “I believe in balance.”

Kael smiled faintly. “Strange choice of word. Not ‘truth,’ not ‘law.’ But balance. Like scales. Weighed. Tilted.”

He stared for a long moment, then turned to leave.

“I’ll return,” he said as he reached the door. “Rain is expected tomorrow.”

Chapter Eight: Confessions to a Dead Woman

That night, Elias walked to Clara’s grave. The cemetery was just outside the city’s edge, surrounded by rusted iron gates and the flickering lights of forgotten candles. He stood before the headstone for a long time, unmoving.

There were no flowers.

Only silence.

“I did it,” he said.

His voice barely broke the air.

“I thought I would feel... something. Relief. Satisfaction. Even horror. But it’s like I struck him and nothing followed. Not the world shifting. Not the weight lifting.”

He knelt in the damp grass.

“I thought it was for you. But maybe it wasn’t. Maybe it was just for me. Maybe I wanted to prove that the world could bleed back.”

The wind moved softly through the trees.

He touched the stone. Cold.

“I’m sorry.”

As he stood to leave, he noticed another headstone nearby — fresh, barely chiseled.

ANNIKA ADELINA ANDELOV — 2016–2025

Elias’s breath caught.

The niece.

She was dead.

Below, etched in trembling script: A heart too small for this world.

He stumbled backward. Was it grief? Was it guilt?

No.

It was realization.

She had seen him.

And she had taken that image with her — buried it.

Was that his punishment?

Or was it just beginning?

Chapter Nine: The Guiltless Man

Kael returned two days later.

He brought tea.

Elias didn't ask why. He poured it, sat, and watched Kael sip from the chipped mug with the same calm as a priest giving last rites.

Kael said, "You know, I once arrested a man for murder. Took me six weeks to find him. He confessed with pride. Said he'd done it to protect his sister. It was clean. He didn't weep. Didn't shake."

Elias said nothing.

Kael smiled. "You're not like him."

"I didn't do anything."

"Didn't you?" Kael set down the mug. "I didn't say you had. Why so quick to defend?"

Elias's knuckles whitened around the cup.

Kael leaned forward. "What if I told you the niece — Annika — drew something before she died? A figure. A man. Long coat. Thin face. Eyes like knives."

Elias whispered, "You're lying."

Kael straightened.

"Would it matter? You already see him in the mirror."

He stood, walked to the door. "You'll hang yourself from guilt long before we charge you. That's what makes you different."

And then he left.

Elias did not move for hours.

Chapter Ten: The Mirror

The mirror in his room was cracked — a thin fracture down the center. It had been that way since he moved in. Tonight, Elias stood before it naked, staring into himself.

His ribs jutted from his skin. His eyes were sunken. He looked like a man returning from war. But the war had not ended.

He touched the glass. Ran his fingers along the split.

The words from his notebook echoed:

“Some truths must be baptized in blood.”

But who had given him that right?

Who had declared him judge, jury, and executioner?

Was it justice, or was it vanity?

Clara had deserved better. But what had Elias become in her name? A shadow. A ghost of himself.

He picked up the notebook. Turned to a blank page.

And wrote:

“It wasn’t punishment. It was escape.

He died for my failure to believe in anything but revenge.

I see now.

The weight I carry is not his death.

It is my life afterward.”

He closed the book.

The mirror cracked a little more.